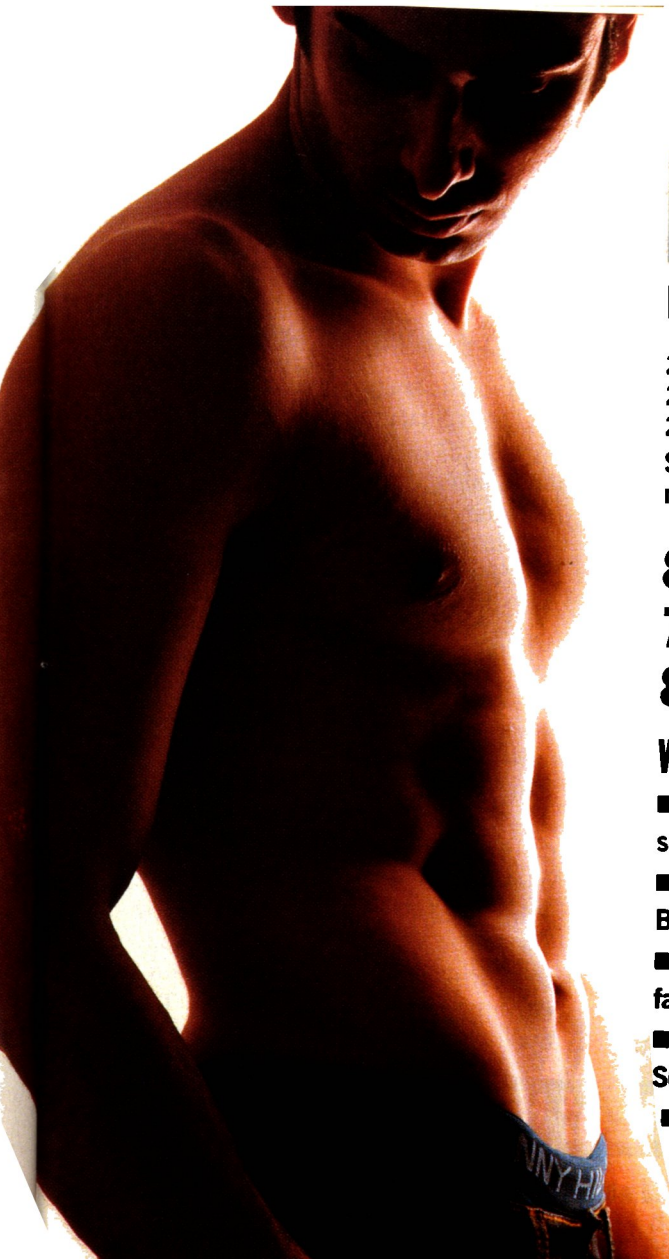




Patient Profile

RIISING MALE FOOTFALL

	MALE	FEMALE
2006-2007	75%	25%
2005-2006	73%	27%
2004-2005	70%	30%

Steady rise of 5-7% in absolute numbers of men seeking surgery

MIDDLE CLASS DRIVING THE BOOM

Low income group: 9%
Middle income group: 67%
High income group: 25%

84% male patients are from urbanites
70% are socially and financially independent
88% men between 25-45 years are unmarried

WHO SEEK SURGERY?

- Those who wish to simply enhance looks. Usually satisfied after surgery; show rise in self-esteem and confidence levels.
- Those who believe surgery will turn their lives and fortunes around. Blame physical appearance for all personal misfortunes.
- Those who are in unstable relationships. Wish to use surgery to save failing relationships. Need psychological counselling.
- Those who are in showbiz, where appearance has a premium. Surgery calls for careful choice of techniques and procedures.
- Those who have minimal deformity but disproportionate body anxiety. May be suffering from Body Dysmorphic Disorder.

(Source: First of its kind study on Aesthetic Plastic Surgery Trends; Dr Sunil Choudhary, Head of the Department, Plastic & Reconstructive Surgery, 600 cosmetic surgery patients, 2004-2007; Max Healthcare, New Delhi.)

macho image," says Dr Ramesh Kumar Sharma, who heads the department of plastic surgery, Post Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research (PGIMER), Chandigarh. At the institute, a decade back, patients were mostly women.

But the number of male clients has rapidly gone up in the last three to four years. "They now form one-fourth of the clientele," says Sharma. Dr Narendra Pandya, consultant at Jaslok Hospital, Mumbai and a pioneer in plastic surgery in India, agrees: "I see at least three times more male cosmetic surgery patients than I did five years ago. Men have become more demanding and aggressive. They believe they have to look presentable to make the cut." Dr S.S. Saha of Gangaram Hospital in Delhi, which gets about 40 such patients per month, notices the

"Surgical aids offer the made-to-order macho image demanded by today's males."

DR RAMESH K. SHARMA, CHANDIGARH

same trend. "Three years back, 90 per cent of our patients were women," he says, "Today, 40 per cent are men." At the Sagar Apollo Hospital in Bangalore, the ratio of men to women has increased in favour of the former. Dr M.S. Venkatesh, head of plastic surgery, says, "Men are taking over women in a number of procedures." Dr Jyotsna Murthy of Ramachandra Hospital in Porur, Chennai, meets software professionals, engineers, businessmen, sports people, film personalities and media professionals. And they all have the same, insatiable desire to look good. "They belong to middle and high income groups, socialise everyday and the moment they gain weight, their

confidence level dips. They will do whatever it takes to get back in shape." Recently, Murthy performed a pectoral implant for a 28-year-old upcoming Tamil actor, increasing his chest size and shape by inserting implants made of solid silicone under the muscle.

Indian males seem to be on the verge of a seismic shift. And they are willing to spend any amount (see box: *The Cost of Looking Good*) in pursuit of their personal look. Check out the numbers: over 70 per cent of India's urban males visit a salon at least once a month for hairstyling, facials and skin-lifting treatment, says an AC Nielsen survey on 1,000 men in four metros, published last month. Three in five single men claim they try to look stylish at all times. An ASSOCHAM survey on 5,000 consumers in August revealed that men's spending on grooming is up by as much as 20 per cent in more than half of Indian families, thanks to the money

BANDEEP SINGH